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The role of Islamic religious education in advancing equality in student participation in physical education: a scoping review

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Introduction: Many middle-school students disengage from physical education (PE) due to fear of judgment, body-image concerns, and a weak sense of belonging. This review explores Islamic Religious Education (IRE) as a value-based framework to foster more equitable participation in PE by cultivating moral awareness, emotional balance, and mutual respect. This study aims to examine how IRE contributes to equality in PE participation by strengthening moral and spiritual readiness, nurturing inclusive learning environments, and sustaining engagement through ethical behavior.

Methods: A scoping review was conducted using the Population, Concept, and Context (PCC) framework to synthesize 40 studies published between 2015 and 2025 in peer-reviewed journals, institutional reports, and Indonesian sources. Evidence was coded in *NVivo* and analyzed through four thematic lenses: (a) moral–psychological readiness, (b) social inclusion and participation inequality, (c) collaboration between IRE and PE teachers, and (d) equitable participation outcomes.

Results: The synthesis indicates that the integration of Islamic values such as self-control (*mujahadah*) and fairness (*'adl*) has the potential to help mitigate performance anxiety and enhance students' confidence, discipline, and motivation. Collaborative teaching involving co-planning and inclusive assessment was perceived to support steadier attendance, stronger engagement, and broader access for girls, students with higher body weight, mild disabilities, and low-income backgrounds.

Discussion: Findings suggest that IRE can function as a moral lever for educational equity when embedded in daily PE routines and reinforced through institutional commitment. Co-designed programs and reflective collaboration between IRE and PE teachers may help reduce participation gaps and strengthen students' readiness to move, learn, and belong.

KEYWORDS
Islamic religious education, physical education, moral development, educational equity, inclusive participation, scoping review

1 Introduction

Engaging in physical activity is one of the most fundamental ways humans sustain their health, well-being, and social growth (Papaioannou et al., 2020). Beyond strengthening the body, regular movement plays a central role in preventing chronic diseases, supporting mental resilience, and improving quality of life across all ages. Recent literature also highlights how movement serves as a social determinant of equity, influencing not only health but also participation opportunities in educational settings (Peñarrubia-Lozano et al., 2020). Yet, despite this broad significance, physical activity is too often understood in a limited sense—as something that happens only in the gym, on the playing field, or during organized sports sessions (Piggin, 2020). This narrow view overlooks the many forms of movement that shape people's daily lives and contribute to their physical and emotional development. Across the last decade (2015–2025), scholars have increasingly reframed school-based physical activity through psychosocial and inclusive lenses, emphasizing engagement, agency, and well-being rather than performance outcomes. In schools, for example, physical education is not merely a venue for athletic performance; it is also a space where students learn cooperation, build self-confidence, and develop habits that can support a healthy and active life (Bessa et al., 2021; Papaioannou et al., 2020). Recognizing these broader dimensions is crucial, especially when schools seek to make participation more inclusive and equitable for students with diverse needs, abilities, and backgrounds.

In the context of school life, physical activity does not always take the form of structured exercise or competitive sports. Students' participation in movement-based learning reflects intersecting social, psychological, moral, and environmental dynamics that influence their willingness to engage (Seifert and Davids, 2017; Solmon, 2015). Some students participate actively because they feel confident or have had positive experiences in the past, while others withdraw due to internal barriers such as anxiety, low self-esteem, or fear of judgment (Westerbeek and Eime, 2021). This situation reflects the reality that physical activity is not merely a matter of physical ability, but is also closely linked to students' emotional, social, and spiritual experiences. Unfortunately, these non-physical dimensions are often overlooked in physical education practices, resulting in less inclusive learning approaches that fail to reach the full potential of all students. Similar participation disparities have been documented globally, with evidence linking motivation loss and exclusion to psychosocial barriers such as anxiety and perceived competence (Rodríguez-Fernández et al., 2021). If these psychological and social aspects are ignored, the main objectives of physical education—to build healthy habits, cooperation, and confidence among all students—will be difficult to achieve (Kao, 2019; Sierra-Díaz et al., 2019). Integrating Islamic Religious Education (IRE) values, such as self-control (*mujahadah*), fairness (*'adl*), and empathy (*rahmah*), can provide ethical guidance that complements physical learning, aiming to support a form of participation in PE that nurtures not only the body but also the moral and emotional well-being of students.

The Indonesian context provides an interesting picture of the complexity of participation in physical activities in educational settings. As a country with vast social, cultural, and economic diversity, schools in Indonesia accommodate students with different backgrounds, experiences, and abilities. These differences often create participation gaps in physical activities. Students from families with limited resources, for instance, may lack access to sports experiences from an early age, while others face psychological barriers such as embarrassment, fear of ridicule, or low self-esteem (Firman et al., 2025). On the other hand, cultural and religious values such as mutual cooperation (gotong royong), fairness (*'adl*), and discipline (*mujahadah*) embedded in Indonesian society hold great potential for fostering a more inclusive physical learning environment (Mariyono, 2024). When physical education is able to integrate these moral-spiritual values through the perspective of Islamic Religious Education (IRE)—which emphasizes empathy, respect for diversity, and collective responsibility—physical activity becomes not only a means of improving health but also a medium for cultivating solidarity, positive identity, and a shared sense of belonging among students (Martín-Rodríguez et al., 2024; Stevens et al., 2017). However, despite this potential, there remains a lack of structured synthesis examining how value-based and religious education approaches have been operationalized to address participation inequities, particularly in developing countries.

In physical education classrooms, participation disparities are also shaped by social hierarchies and gender constructs that students bring from their surrounding environments (Gupta, 2018). Boys are often perceived as more suited to competitive and performance-oriented activities, making them more dominant in occupying physical spaces and expressing their voices, while many female students hesitate due to body-image concerns, fear of judgment, or practical constraints such as menstrual management and dress codes. Students who are heavier, have mild disabilities, or come from low-income families frequently experience subtle teasing, restricted access to equipment, or lower expectations from peers. Cultural and religious norms—such as preferences for non-contact activities or expectations of modesty—can also limit participation choices (Hills et al., 2015). When these intersecting factors are not acknowledged, physical activity may become an arena of exclusion: some students gain confidence and visibility, while others become marginalized or disengaged.

In this context, Islamic Religious Education (IRE) offers a moral and pedagogical foundation for addressing these disparities. By emphasizing values such as justice (*'adl*), empathy (*rahmah*), and cooperation (*ta'awun*), IRE can challenge stereotypes, foster mutual respect, and build students' moral confidence to participate more equitably in physical activities. Integrating these principles within PE lessons encourages ethical competition, promotes gender sensitivity, and reframes physical activity as a shared responsibility rather than a contest of dominance. These patterns align with global findings showing that gendered expectations, economic inequality, and perceived ability continue to influence participation, yet moral and value-based educational frameworks remain underexplored in comparative analyses of these factors (Fletcher et al., 2018).

Although schools often position physical education within the domains of fitness and motor skills development (Gomes et al., 2023), few reviews have systematically explored the potential of Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in promoting equitable participation (Thorburn and Stolz, 2017). Limited attention has been paid to how vulnerable bodily experiences, feelings of shame, gender stereotypes, or socioeconomic constraints discourage some students from active involvement (Martín-Rodríguez et al., 2024; Stevens et al., 2017). This gap risks normalizing inequality—treating low participation as a matter of individual motivation rather than the result of social and moral barriers that can be addressed through inclusive pedagogical support.

Within this context, IRE can act as a moral and ethical framework embedded in the PE ecosystem—identifying invisible barriers, strengthening moral confidence, and promoting collaborative strategies between PE and IRE teachers, parents, and students (Penney et al., 2002). By linking physical activity to values such as justice (*'adl*), empathy (*rahmah*), and perseverance (*mujahadah*), schools can redefine movement as both a physical and ethical practice. Without such a moral foundation, it is easy to overlook how movement, identity, and social relations are intertwined, and how value-based education can tangibly expand equitable access to participation for all learners.

To address this gap, this study presents a scoping review of interdisciplinary literature published between 2015 and 2025 that examines the relationship between Islamic Religious Education (IRE) and equitable participation in physical education at the junior high school level, with a particular focus on the Indonesian context while referencing relevant global findings. The review maps evidence on: (1) how moral and psychological barriers—such as performance anxiety, body image, and feelings of inadequacy—affect students' willingness to participate; (2) how social factors such as gender, socioeconomic status, and mild disabilities shape participation experiences in PE classes; and (3) strategies employed collaboratively by IRE and PE teachers—ranging from moral reflection sessions, value-based goal setting, peer cooperation, to flexible and inclusive assessment—to expand access and sustain engagement.

By synthesizing these diverse approaches, this study shifts the focus of physical education from performance-centered goals toward an inclusive framework that integrates moral, spiritual, and psychosocial well-being. Its main contribution is to position Islamic Religious Education as a key moral and pedagogical component of an inclusive PE ecosystem—one that connects physical activity with broader educational agendas of equity, character formation, and holistic student development.

To guide this scoping review, the following research questions (RQs) were formulated based on the Population, Concept, and Context (PCC) framework:

- RQ1: How do moral and psychological barriers (e.g., anxiety, body image) affect junior high school students' participation in PE?
- RQ2: In what ways do social factors (gender, socioeconomic status) shape participation inequalities in the Indonesian and global context?
- RQ3: What collaborative strategies between IRE and PE teachers are identified in the literature to promote inclusive and equitable participation?

2 Method

2.1 Research design

His study applied a scoping review design to synthesize existing evidence on the role of Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in promoting equitable participation in junior high school physical education (PE) learning. This approach was selected because the topic is relatively new, interdisciplinary—spanning educational psychology, moral education, adolescent health, educational sociology, and physical education—and requires mapping a broad corpus of literature rather than evaluating narrow interventions.

Following the methodological framework of the *Joanna Briggs Institute* (JBI) (Stern et al., 2018), the review process proceeded through five iterative stages: (1) Formulating research questions and operational definitions—including key constructs such as participation, equity, moral–spiritual readiness, and IRE–PE collaboration; (2) Identifying relevant studies across multiple databases (Scopus, Web of Science, PubMed, ERIC) and gray literature sources (ministerial guidelines, institutional reports, school policy documents), complemented by citation chasing; (3) Applying inclusion–exclusion criteria based on the PCC scheme (Population: junior high school students or equivalents, PE and IRE teachers; Concept: moral, ethical, or religious education strategies linked to participation and equality; Context: school-based physical education); (4) Charting and coding key variables—including study characteristics, moral-psychological barriers, pedagogical integration mechanisms, collaboration models between IRE and PE teachers, and indicators of equitable participation—using qualitative analysis software (*NVivo*) with a documented audit trail; and (5) Synthesizing findings into cross-study thematic categories that capture recurring mechanisms and their implications for practice.

To enhance transparency and reproducibility, the search protocol and inclusion logic were documented prior to data collection, serving as a de facto preregistration although not formally deposited in an open repository. Reporting followed the *PRISMA-ScR* guidelines (including a *PRISMA* flow diagram for study selection transparency) (Tricco et al., 2018). The analytic logic and corpus organization adhered to Tricco et al. (2018) recommendations for scoping reviews, emphasizing iterative refinement and systematic evidence charting across sources. Although a formal protocol was not registered, the review plan was developed prospectively to maintain methodological consistency and replicability throughout all stages.

2.2 Inclusion and exclusion criteria

This review covers publications from 2015 to 2025 in the form of peer-reviewed articles and official reports from credible institutions, both international and Indonesian. The temporal range (2015–2025) was selected to capture the last decade of policy and scholarly attention on equity-oriented moral and religious education within physical education (PE), a period during which inclusion, ethics, and psychosocial frameworks have gained increasing international traction (Tolgfors, 2020).

Studies were considered eligible if they explicitly linked Islamic Religious Education (IRE)—or comparable moral/religious educational approaches—with participation, equality, or inclusiveness in PE at the junior high school or lower secondary level. Acceptable forms of evidence included: (a) Value-based or moral interventions (individual/group reflections, ethical goal setting, peer cooperation, inclusive evaluation) addressing barriers to participation such as performance anxiety, body image, gender stereotypes, socioeconomic status, and mild disabilities; (b) Qualitative or mixed-methods studies describing student experiences, the role of moral education, and collaboration between IRE and PE teachers in daily practice; (c) Quantitative studies measuring participation-related outcomes (PE attendance, task engagement, willingness to participate) and/or psychological–moral mediators (self-efficacy, motivation, sense of belonging); and (d) School or ministry policies/guidelines incorporating moral, religious, or psychosocial support frameworks to expand equitable access to physical activity.

Publications in both English and Indonesian were included to capture a broad spectrum of relevant discourse. For gray literature, only documents issued by government ministries, accredited universities, or international organizations (e.g., UNESCO, WHO) were accepted. Informal sources such as blogs or non-verified reports were excluded to ensure credibility.

Sources were excluded if: (a) they did not connect IRE, moral/religious education, or value-based instruction with PE or equality of participation (e.g., focused solely on sports performance or technical skills without an ethical dimension); (b) they focused on inappropriate populations (e.g., higher education or professional athletes) without data transferable to the junior high school context; (c) they were opinion essays, editorials, preprints without peer review, or gray literature from sources lacking institutional credibility; (d) they discussed physical activity or school health without participation indicators or value-based inclusion components; (e) they addressed PE technology or curriculum innovations without reference to psychosocial or moral barriers; or (f) full text or key data for extraction were unavailable.

Consistent application of these criteria ensured a coherent and rigorous final corpus, contributing directly to understanding how Islamic Religious Education can promote equality and inclusiveness in PE at the junior high school level.

2.3 Search strategy

To gather relevant cross-disciplinary evidence, a comprehensive and iterative search strategy was developed. Seven electronic databases were systematically searched: Scopus, Web of Science, PubMed, ERIC, PsycINFO, ScienceDirect, and DOAJ, supplemented by GARUDA (the Indonesian National Index) and Google Scholar for initial retrieval and citation chasing. This combination ensured coverage of both international peer-reviewed literature and national publications in Indonesian. The final search was conducted on May 20, 2025.

Credible gray literature was systematically included—specifically documents from the Ministry of Religious Affairs; Ministry of Education, Culture, Research, and Technology; Ministry of Health; and UNESCO/WHO guidelines. Given that Islamic Religious Education (IRE) integration often operates at the policy or institutional level rather than solely through empirical trials, including these high-quality non-journal sources was deemed essential. Excluding them would overlook the regulatory frameworks that shape moral education in Indonesian schools and potentially introduce publication bias.

Keywords were developed gradually—From broad to specific—And adjusted according to each database's controlled vocabulary (e.g., MeSH for PubMed ERIC thesaurus for ERIC). The Boolean string examples below illustrate the main search logic after adaptation from the original counseling-based terms:

Scopus/Web of Science (Boolean Example):

("Islamic Religious Education" OR "moral education" OR "religious instruction" OR "pendidikan agama Islam" OR "PAI") AND ("physical education" OR "PE" OR "*pendidikan jasmani*") AND (equity OR equality OR inclusion OR "inclusive education" OR *kesetaraan* OR *inklusif**) AND (adolescent OR "middle school" OR "lower secondary" OR "SMP")

PubMed Example (MeSH):

(("Religious Education"[MeSH] OR "Moral Development"[All Fields]) AND ("Motor Activity"[MeSH] OR "Exercise"[MeSH] OR "Physical Education and Training"[MeSH])) AND ("Students"[MeSH] OR "Adolescent"[MeSH]) AND ("Equity"[All Fields] OR "Educational Status"[MeSH] OR "Social Inclusion"[MeSH])

ERIC Example (Descriptors):

DE:"Religious Education" OR DE:"Moral Education" AND DE:"Physical Education" AND (DE: Equity OR DE:"Inclusive Education") AND (DE: Adolescents OR DE:"Middle School Students").

GARUDA / Indonesian Sources:

("pendidikan agama Islam" OR "*pendidikan moral*") AND ("*pendidikan jasmani*" OR "physical education") AND (*kesetaraan* OR *inklusif* OR "*pembelajaran partisipatif*") AND ("SMP" OR "*remaja*").

Searches were limited to the 2015–2025 timeframe and conducted in both English and Indonesian. Search equations were adapted per platform—for instance, title/abstract field restrictions in Scopus and subject/descriptor filters in ERIC. Initial search results were exported to Mendeley for automatic deduplication and verified manually. Screening occurred in two stages: (1) Title–abstract screening to determine preliminary relevance; and (2) Full-text screening to confirm eligibility against PCC criteria.

Backward and forward citation chasing was performed from the reference lists of included studies to identify additional relevant sources. All inclusion and exclusion decisions were documented in a detailed worksheet, recording search dates, Boolean strings, applied filters, and the number of records at each step to maintain a complete audit trail and ensure replicability. A search performance summary (Table 1) presents the number of records retrieved from each database, retained after deduplication, screened at title–abstract level, and confirmed through full-text eligibility—providing transparent traceability of evidence flow consistent with the *PRISMA-ScR* framework.

2.4 Study selection and data extraction

The selection process was conducted in sequential stages to ensure accuracy and transparency. All search results from databases and institutional repositories were exported to a reference manager (*Mendeley*) for initial organization. Duplicates were removed through automatic detection and manually verified to ensure that similar titles with different editions or publication details were not mistakenly deleted. The cleaned dataset was then imported into *NVivo* for initial tagging and organization.

Two reviewers independently screened titles and abstracts according to predetermined inclusion and exclusion criteria (PCC). Potentially relevant records proceeded to full-text reading. Any differences in inclusion decisions were discussed until consensus was reached, and where disagreement persisted, a third reviewer was consulted. Inter-rater reliability was ensured by calibrating coding decisions at two intervals, achieving an agreement rate above 85%, which met the *Joanna Briggs Institute* (JBI) threshold for consistency. This multi-stage procedure was designed to minimize bias and increase reviewer reliability throughout the screening process.

For each study that passed the final screening, a structured data extraction sheet—pilot-tested for consistency—was used. The recorded variables included: author and year, school location/context, population (junior high school students or equivalent, PE and IRE teachers), IRE-based components (e.g., moral reflection sessions, value-oriented goal setting, peer collaboration, ethical feedback, inclusive assessment), barriers to participation addressed (performance anxiety, body image, gender stereotypes, socioeconomic status, mild disabilities), forms of collaboration between IRE and PE teachers, and

TABLE 1 Summary of included studies.

No	Author(s), year	Study design	Geographical scope	Primary focus
1	Aartun et al. (2022)	Literature review	Global	Embodied pedagogies and holistic learning in PE
2	Anttila et al. (2018)	Qualitative reflections	Finland	Intercultural encounters and teachers as moral–social agents
3	Arufe-Giráldez et al. (2023)	Rapid review	Global	Pedagogical models fostering equity and inclusion in PE
4	Barker (2019)	Qualitative	UK	Teacher perspectives, diversity, and fairness in PE contexts
5	Berg et al. (2015)	Public health perspective	Global	Leisure-time physical activity as a health and social equity tool
6	Bessa et al. (2021)	Quantitative intervention	Portugal	Sport education and students' empowerment and confidence
7	Fletcher et al. (2018)	Policy/clinical review	Global	Physical activity and psychosocial promotion
8	Firman et al. (2025)	Qualitative	Indonesia	Gender, labor, and community cohesion as moral dimensions of activity
9	Gupta (2018)	Conceptual analysis	India	Inclusive approaches for persons with disabilities
10	Hastie et al. (2011)	Scoping review	Global	Research trends in Sport Education model
11	Hastie and Wallhead (2016)	Conceptual article	Global	Models-based practice in PE emphasizing cooperation
12	Hills et al. (2015)	Policy recommendations	Global	PE's contribution to public health and equality agendas
13	Izquierdo and Fiatarone Singh (2023)	Narrative review	Global	Resilience, aging, and well-being through physical activity
14	Kao (2019)	Intervention study	Taiwan	Team cohesion and collaboration in sport education
15	Lambert et al. (2024)	Concept analysis	Global	Theoretical conceptualizations of embodiment in PE
16	MacPhail et al. (2003)	Qualitative	UK	Students' conceptions of cooperation and belonging in sport education
17	MacPhail et al. (2004)	Mixed methods	UK	Team affiliation and shared moral responsibility in PE
18	Mariyono (2024)	Policy analysis	Indonesia	Integration of cultural and moral education in Indonesian schools
19	Opstoel et al. (2019)	Scoping review	Europe	Personal and social development outcomes in PE and sports
20	Papaioannou et al. (2020)	Commentary	Global	Physical activity, well-being, and holistic health
21	Peñarrubia-Lozano et al. (2020)	Intervention study	Spain	Using challenges to foster motivation and moral engagement in PE
22	Penney et al. (2002)	Conceptual paper	UK	Sport education as a connective and inclusive pedagogical model

(Continued)

TABLE 1 (Continued)

No	Author(s), year	Study design	Geographical scope	Primary focus
23	Piggin (2020)	Conceptual article	Global	Defining physical activity beyond performance toward moral meaning
24	Rhodes et al. (2019)	Literature synthesis	Global	Theories of physical activity behavior and self-efficacy
25	Roux (2000)	Conceptual article	South Africa	Multireligious education and moral coexistence in PE curricula
26	Seifert and Davids (2017)	Theoretical framework	Global	Ecological dynamics and inclusive learning design
27	Siedentop (2001)	Retrospective review	USA	Historical perspectives on sport education as cooperative learning
28	Sierra-Díaz et al. (2019)	Scoping review & meta-analysis	Global	Motivation and engagement through inclusive models-based practice
29	Siljamäki and Anttila (2021)	Conceptual article	Finland	Developing intercultural and ethical competence in PE teachers
30	Sillar (2016)	Anthropological chapter	Andes	Agency, ritual movement, and moral symbolism in agrarian culture
31	Solmon (2015)	Conceptual framework	USA	Social-ecological framework to promote equitable participation
32	Spittle and Byrne (2009)	Quantitative	Australia	Sport education's impact on student motivation and fairness
33	Stevens et al. (2017)	Conceptual	Global	Social identity and inclusion through physical activity
34	Taylor et al. (2023)	Scoping review	Global	Physical and psychological well-being under social inequality
35	Thorburn and Stolz (2017)	Conceptual article	UK	Embodied learning and moral professionalism in PE
36	Thorjussen and Sisjord (2018)	Qualitative	Norway	Students' experiences in multi-ethnic and religiously diverse PE classes
37	Tolgfors (2020)	Conceptual paper	Sweden	Integration and equality through inclusive physical education
38	Walseth (2015)	Qualitative	Norway	Muslim girls' experiences, modesty, and religiosity in PE
39	Waters et al. (2018)	Qualitative	Ecuador	Physical labor, gender, and ethical dimensions of participation
40	Xiong et al. (2020)	Qualitative	China	Physical activity and moral-social integration of migrant women

participation or engagement indicators (PE attendance, willingness to participate, perceived inclusivity, and moral-spiritual readiness).

Initial data were charted in Excel for cross-study comparison and subsequently imported into *NVivo* for inductive thematic coding. Coding proceeded iteratively—from open coding to focused grouping—until clear thematic categories emerged that supported the synthesis presented in the findings section. This combined approach—structured data charting and qualitative thematic analysis—ensured both comprehensive coverage and interpretive depth in explaining how Islamic Religious Education functions to promote equitable participation in physical education at the junior high school level. The extraction sheet and coding manual were also cross-validated by an external expert in moral and educational psychology to ensure interpretive alignment between the domains of IRE and PE.

2.5 Data analysis

The analysis process followed the principles of thematic analysis with an inductive approach, allowing patterns and themes to emerge naturally from the data rather than being imposed *a priori*.

To maintain analytic rigor, coding cycles adhered to Braun and Clarke's six-phase framework while ensuring alignment with the moral–spiritual and social–ecological lenses underpinning this review.

After data extraction, all texts were entered into *NVivo* to facilitate systematic tagging, organization, and retrieval of key excerpts. To ensure transparency and replicability, the coding hierarchy was organized into three levels:

1 Parent Nodes derived initially from the PCC framework (e.g., 'Barriers,' 'Pedagogy,' 'Outcomes');
2 Child Nodes emerging inductively from the text (e.g., under 'Barriers': 'Body Image,' 'Gender Stereotypes,' 'Anxiety'); and
3 Thematic Aggregates where related child nodes were synthesized into broader conceptual categories. A sample of the coding tree is available in Appendix B. to illustrate the synthesis process.

We began with open coding for each study, capturing ideas about moral and psychological barriers, social dynamics, and collaborative practices. Overlapping codes were consolidated, synonymous terms were merged, and related groups were elevated into mid-level categories to reveal broader thematic structures.

To assess the robustness of the evidence, a methodological appraisal was performed using the JBI Critical Appraisal Tools for qualitative and quantitative designs; a summary is presented in Appendix A, Table A1. Studies with lower quality ratings were retained only when they offered unique contextual or cultural insights absent in higher-quality evidence, and were interpreted with caution.

The coding process yielded several core thematic categories:

1 Moral–psychological empowerment through IRE-based learning (reduced anxiety, strengthened discipline, enhanced self-efficacy);
2 Social inclusion and equality in PE participation (integration of fairness [*'adl*], empathy [*rahmah*], and cooperation [*ta'awun*] values);
3 IRE–PE collaboration mechanisms (joint reflection sessions, ethical goal setting, peer cooperation, and flexible moral assessment); and
4 Participation and engagement indicators (attendance consistency, willingness to participate, and strengthened sense of belonging).

These categories were synthesized into thematic narratives explaining how Islamic Religious Education has the potential to function as an ethical and pedagogical lever for justice—reshaping classroom norms, reducing preventable barriers, and fostering students' readiness to engage actively and respectfully.

The analytic depth was reinforced through source triangulation (peer-reviewed studies, official reports, and school or ministry policy documents) to ensure that emerging themes reflected diverse disciplinary perspectives. The review team also conducted reflexive discussions throughout the analysis to minimize interpretive bias and maintain coding consistency. Reflexive memos were documented to trace key analytic decisions and enhance transparency in theme construction.

The final synthesis presents a structured account of how IRE operates as moral support, a driver of equality, and a pedagogical collaborator in developing more equitable participation in physical education within Indonesian junior high schools.

3 Results

The literature search and screening process is summarized in the PRISMA flow diagram (Figure 1). This process adhered to the PRISMA-ScR reporting guidelines to ensure methodological transparency and reproducibility. From the initial search conducted across international and national databases, along with credible gray literature sources, a total of 90 publications relevant to the research topic were identified.

Following the stages of deduplication, title and abstract screening, and systematic application of inclusion–exclusion criteria, the dataset was substantially refined. Ultimately, 40 studies met the eligibility criteria and were included in the final synthesis. These studies constituted the analytical foundation for identifying recurring patterns, thematic categories, and mechanisms related to the role of Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in promoting equitable participation among junior high school students within physical education (PE) learning contexts.

The *PRISMA* flow diagram (Figure 1) illustrates each step of the selection process—from initial identification to final inclusion—while Table 1 provides a concise summary of the studies that passed the final screening stage. Together, they ensure a transparent trace of evidence flow and establish the empirical basis for the thematic synthesis presented in the subsequent sections.

This diagram illustrates the process of identifying, screening, and selecting studies included in the scoping review. A total of 90 records were initially identified from various international databases and institutional repositories. After the deduplication process, 82 records remained and were screened based on their titles and abstracts, with 32 subsequently excluded for lacking relevance to the focus of this review. The remaining 50 articles underwent a full-text eligibility assessment, during which 10 were excluded for not meeting the established inclusion criteria. The final synthesis therefore included 40 studies, which were analyzed thematically.

Table 1 summarizes the characteristics of the included studies, detailing author names, publication year, research design, geographic scope, and principal thematic focus. The selected studies represent a range of disciplines, including educational psychology, physical education, moral and religious education, and adolescent health, reflecting the inherently multidisciplinary nature of research examining the role of Islamic Religious Education (IRE) in promoting equitable participation within PE at the junior high school level.

Although this review primarily focused on studies published between 2015 and 2025, several earlier foundational works were retained as conceptual references to trace the theoretical evolution of inclusive, equity-oriented, and value-based physical education. These pre-2015 studies were not included in the formal synthesis but served as background sources to contextualize more recent empirical findings.

Of the 40 included studies, approximately 55% reported improved student engagement or attendance, 35% associated Islamic Religious Education (IRE) or value-based instruction with enhanced moral confidence, discipline, and self-efficacy, while around 25% directly examined participation inequities related to gender, body

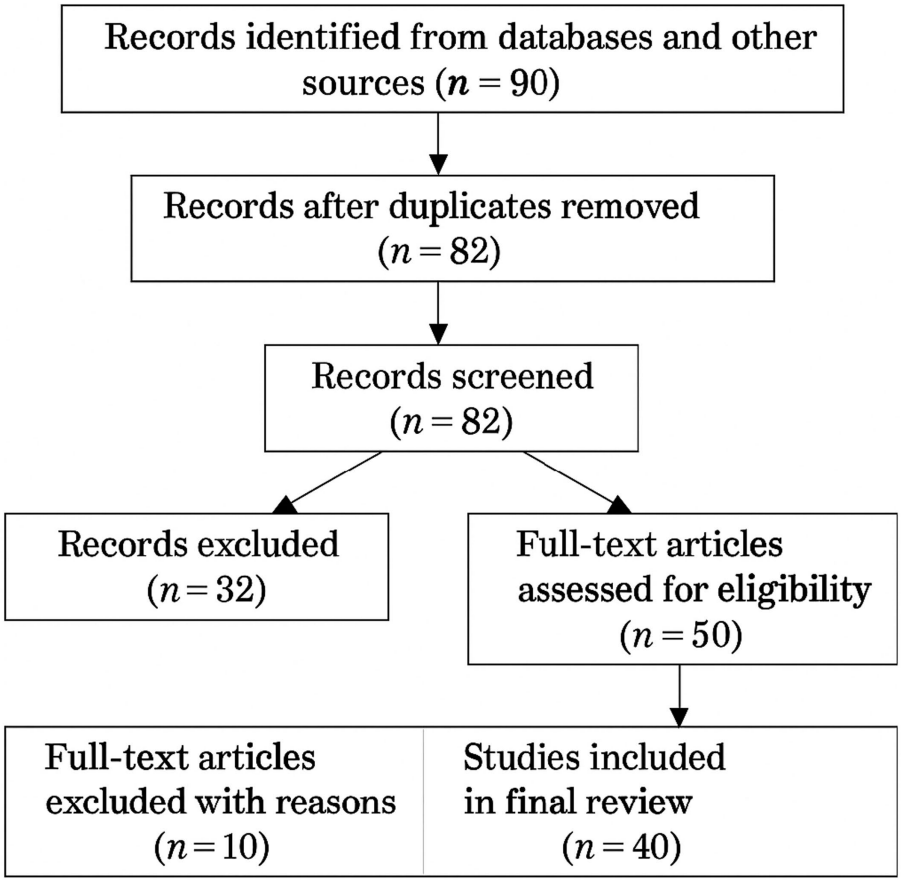


FIGURE 1
PRISMA flow diagram.

image, or socioeconomic background. The methodological quality of these studies was assessed using the *Joanna Briggs Institute* (JBI) Critical Appraisal Tool, adapted to match each study's design. Table A1. presents the quality assessment results, indicating that most studies were of moderate to high quality. Common strengths included a clear formulation of research objectives, the use of appropriate analytical approaches, and consistent reporting of findings. Frequently observed weaknesses included small sample sizes, limited researcher reflexivity, and insufficient discussion of contextual or confounding factors.

Based on this appraisal, coding supported by *NVivo* software generated 215 initial codes, which were refined and grouped thematically into four major themes: (1) Moral–psychological empowerment of students through IRE-based learning (reduction of anxiety, development of self-control, and strengthened self-efficacy); (2) Social inclusion and reduction of participation barriers in physical education through moral and ethical values such as fairness (*'adl*), cooperation (*ta'awun*), and compassion (*rahmah*); (3) Strategic collaboration between IRE and PE teachers in fostering a morally grounded and inclusive learning environment; and (4) The impact of equitable participation on students' engagement, confidence, and overall well-being.

Each theme is elaborated in the following section, supported by illustrative evidence from the reviewed literature. Collectively, these findings reveal a multidimensional understanding of equality in physical education, emphasizing that moral readiness, social inclusion, and pedagogical collaboration are mutually reinforcing elements that shape students' holistic participation in PE (Figure 2).

A detailed summary of the methodological quality of the 40 included studies, evaluated using the *Joanna Briggs Institute* (JBI) Critical Appraisal Tools, is presented in Appendix A, Table A1. Overall, most studies were rated as moderate to high quality, demonstrating clearly stated research objectives, appropriate analytical approaches, and consistent reporting of findings across diverse contexts.

Comprehensive quality-assessment checklists and evaluator notes are available in Appendix A, ensuring transparency and methodological rigor in evaluating the evidence base used for this review.

3.1 Psychological impacts of Islamic religious education

Analysis using *NVivo* indicates that moral–psychological dimensions are the most prominent focus across the reviewed literature. The majority of studies reveal that the primary barriers to student participation in physical education are not merely physical or technical, but instead arise from internal psychological and moral conditions that influence students' readiness to move, cooperate, and engage. These barriers often manifest as anxiety, fear of judgment, low self-esteem, or limited self-discipline—factors that hinder equitable participation and diminish students' sense of belonging.

Within this context, integrating Islamic Religious Education (IRE) offers a moral framework that aims to nurtureemotional balance, ethical self-awareness, and intrinsic motivation. By emphasizing values such as *mujahadah* (self-control), *'adl* (fairness), and *ta'awun*

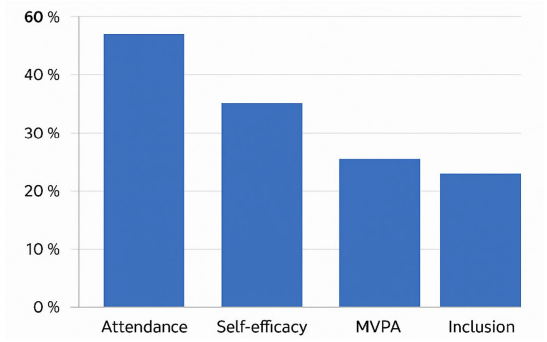


FIGURE 2
Distribution of outcomes reported across included studies (attendance, self-efficacy, MVPA, inclusion). This figure provides a visual summary of the proportion of studies reporting positive outcomes related to participation, motivation, and moral–psychological readiness in physical education contexts. These outcomes reflect how the integration of Islamic Religious Education (IRE) and value-based learning contributes to fostering equitable engagement and inclusive participation in PE.

(cooperation), IRE was reported to support students in developing the confidence and discipline necessary to participate more fully in physical education (Table 2).

The table above shows that four main dimensions dominate the thematic coding results. Performance anxiety and fear of judgment emerged as the most frequent moral–psychological barriers, followed by self-efficacy and confidence building, intrinsic motivation, and coping strategies with emotional regulation. This pattern highlights that internal emotional and moral dynamics strongly influence how far students are willing to participate actively in physical education (PE) activities.

In this context, IRE appears to play a central role in addressing these psychological pressures through moral guidance and reflective value-based learning. Instead of focusing solely on cognitive or physical aspects, IRE fosters emotional awareness and moral balance, helping students recognize their feelings, regulate fear, and strengthen positive attitudes toward physical activity. Several studies in this review demonstrate that IRE-integrated strategies—such as reflective self-assessment and cooperative tasks emphasizing *ta'awun* (mutual support)—can enhance students' moral confidence and intrinsic motivation to participate.

The effectiveness of this value-based approach depends largely on the collaboration between IRE and PE teachers and the inclusiveness of classroom social climates. In supportive contexts, integrating moral reflection within PE was observed to transform negative emotions—such as embarrassment or fear—into opportunities for self-growth. Conversely, when such integration is weak, students often continue to experience insecurity. This underscores the importance of positioning IRE as a core pedagogical framework for cultivating psychological resilience—enabling students to participate more actively and meaningfully.

3.2 Social inclusion and participation inequality

Analysis using *NVivo* reveals that social inclusion and participation inequality are among the most recurrent themes in the reviewed literature, emphasizing how social, cultural, and structural factors

TABLE 2 Distribution of *NVivo* coded references on psychological dimensions of islamic religious education.

Code category	Number of references	% of Total
Performance anxiety and fear of judgment	62	28.8
Self-efficacy and confidence building	58	27.0
Motivation and intrinsic engagement	51	23.7
Coping strategies and emotional regulation	44	20.5

shape students' experiences within PE. The findings indicate that participation in PE is not a neutral or purely physical process; rather, it is deeply influenced by gender stereotypes, socioeconomic background, physical ability, and body image, which collectively construct subtle yet persistent barriers for certain groups of students.

From the perspective of IRE, these barriers can be interpreted as moral challenges that call for the cultivation of justice (*'adl*) and compassion (*rahmah*). By embedding these values into classroom culture, teachers can help reframe physical education as a space of inclusion and mutual respect, where diversity is viewed as a source of cooperation rather than competition.

The table above presents the five dominant categories emerging from thematic coding on social inclusion and participation inequality. Gender stereotypes appear as the most cited barrier, followed by body-image concerns, socioeconomic constraints, discrimination toward students with mild disabilities, and the influence of cultural or familial expectations.

For instance, female students often withdraw from competitive or high-visibility activities due to modesty norms, body-image anxiety, or prior experiences of ridicule. Likewise, students who are overweight or have mild disabilities frequently encounter subtle exclusion, limited opportunities to demonstrate competence, and stigmatizing comments—all of which reinforce feelings of inadequacy and social distance.

Coding results show that references to social exclusion frequently co-occur with nodes such as body image, peer stigma, and perceived incompetence, indicating that inequality stems not only from physical capability but also from psychosocial and moral dimensions that shape self-esteem and identity. These barriers are further compounded by socioeconomic disparities: students from low-income households may lack access to sports equipment or parental encouragement, reducing both readiness and motivation to participate.

Within this context, IRE serves as a moral and pedagogical bridge to dismantle such social barriers. Through reflective discussions rooted in values of justice (*'adl*), compassion (*rahmah*), and mutual support (*ta'awun*), IRE encourages empathy, fairness, and solidarity among students. Collaborative efforts between IRE and PE teachers—such as joint reflection sessions on stereotypes, cooperative peer-learning groups, and value-based activity design—help establish a safe and inclusive environment where students can participate without fear of judgment.

As these inclusive practices take root, previously hesitant students begin to engage more actively, while exclusive norms once accepted as "natural" gradually shift toward equitable and compassionate

participation. These findings affirm that inequality in PE reflects broader social structures and moral hierarchies, and that value-based education can play a transformative role in reshaping those spaces. Achieving fairness in participation therefore requires not only redesigning physical activities but also addressing the social, emotional, and ethical dimensions that restrict student involvement. Through this integrative approach, IRE-infused pedagogy nurtures belonging, self-respect, and confidence—ensuring that every student has equal opportunity to move, learn, and grow within the physical-education environment.

3.3 Collaboration between IRE and PE teachers in creating inclusive learning environments

Analysis using *NVivo* shows that IRE–PE teacher collaboration and inclusive pedagogical practices occupy a central position across the reviewed literature. Rather than functioning as an additional or peripheral element, IRE emerges as a pedagogical partner—supporting teachers in designing learning objectives, aligning moral and psychosocial guidance with physical activities, and reorganizing classroom routines to ensure that participation becomes safer, fairer, and more meaningful for all students.

In many studies, the most visible transformations occurred when IRE and PE teachers planned together—setting achievable moral and learning goals, choosing cooperative group formats, and designing assessment systems that respected students' diverse abilities. This shared planning not only improved instructional quality but also cultivated a more empathetic classroom climate grounded in mutual respect and ethical awareness.

The table above shows that co-planning (24.3%) and inclusive lesson design (22.8%) are the most frequent categories, followed by flexible assessment, peer collaboration, and restorative classroom practices. These categories reflect a pedagogical pattern in which moral reflection, inclusivity, and cooperation operate as core mechanisms of equitable participation.

Key strategies identified in the literature include task differentiation and inclusive lesson design, allowing students to contribute according to their physical and emotional readiness while maintaining an appropriate level of challenge. Flexible assessment methods—such as skill demonstrations, reflective journals, or process-based evaluations—help reduce performance anxiety and validate individual progress. Peer support structures, such as cooperative learning teams grounded in *ta'awun* (mutual help), foster a sense of belonging and shared responsibility. Meanwhile, restorative practices and positive classroom climate routines normalize mistakes as part of moral and personal growth, reinforcing the value of *mujahadah* (self-discipline) and *rahmah* (compassion) in learning.

NVivo co-occurrence queries revealed strong linkages among "co-planning," "task differentiation," "flexible assessment," "peer support," and "restorative practices." This pattern confirms that cross-role collaboration not only transforms instructional design but also shifts classroom norms—from performance-driven assessment toward empathy-driven participation; from competition and selection toward intentional inclusion.

Overall, these findings indicate that IRE–PE collaboration functions as a crucial lever for addressing both psychological and social barriers to participation while improving the moral quality of the learning experience. When inclusive pedagogical practices are enriched with moral reflection and value-based guidance, students who were once hesitant begin to engage actively, take initiative, and participate consistently in physical education.

3.4 Equitable participation and student well-being

A cross-study synthesis shows that when IRE is integrated with inclusive pedagogical practices, the most visible change occurs in the quality of student participation in PE. Students' involvement is no longer defined merely by presence or compliance, but by how safe, accepted, and capable they feel when participating alongside peers. Many reports indicate that students who were initially passive began to attend lessons more consistently, were willing to attempt motor tasks they had previously avoided, and demonstrated greater perseverance in moderate-to-vigorous physical activity (MVPA). Inhibiting psychological symptoms—such as fear of ridicule or anxiety during performance evaluation—gradually subsided through moral-emotional reflection, value-based encouragement, and a more compassionate classroom climate.

The synthesis identifies several recurring mechanisms of change. IRE-infused interventions—such as gradual goal-setting inspired by *mujahadah* (self-discipline), peer-support grounded in *ta'awun* (mutual help), and structured moral reflection—enhanced students' self-efficacy and positive emotional attachment to movement. At the same time, collaboration between IRE and PE teachers fostered inclusive lesson design and flexible assessment systems that reduced performance pressure. These combined practices nurtured a positive PE climate, where classroom norms shifted from "who is the strongest" toward celebrating individual growth and moral effort. As a result, participation gaps by gender, body weight, mild disability, or socioeconomic background narrowed—not because of numerical enforcement, but because underlying psychosocial and moral barriers were actively addressed.

Three clusters of outcome indicators emerged consistently: (1) Belonging and PE climate: students reported greater comfort receiving feedback, increased cooperation, and reduced teasing; (2) Engagement and persistence: higher task engagement from start to finish, stronger willingness to retry difficult movements, and more perseverance during challenges; (3) Active behavior and readiness: longer active minutes per lesson and improved behavioral readiness.

Parallel improvements were noted in well-being and self-esteem; students described feeling "braver," "more capable," and "more accepted". *NVivo* co-occurrence analysis revealed frequent clustering of belonging–engagement–MVPA, suggesting that psychological safety, moral climate, and physical activity reinforce one another.

Sustainability of these gains depended on simple yet consistent monitoring routines—tracking attendance, logging active minutes, documenting IRE-PE reflection sessions, and recording weekly student self-notes. Schools that systematically reviewed these data in joint IRE–PE meetings maintained inclusion outcomes longer. In short, equitable participation is not the result of a single intervention but the product of coordinated, continuous, and morally guided practice that integrates ethics, empathy, and evidence into everyday PE learning.

The table above summarizes the most frequent outcomes: belonging and classroom climate occupy the largest share, followed by engagement and persistence, active behavior, well-being and self-esteem, and narrowing participation gaps. The pattern confirms that equity in participation is nurtured through moral-psychological support, inclusive teaching design, and continuous reflection, all centered on movement as both a physical and ethical practice within education.

3.5 Summary of thematic findings

This summary integrates the results of *NVivo* coding, the distribution tables (Tables 3–5), and the overall narrative synthesis across the corpus. In general, the reviewed studies consistently highlight physical activity in Physical Education (PE) as the core domain, while Islamic Religious Education (IRE) acts as a value-based lever that expands equitable participation through moral, psychological, and pedagogical pathways.

At the psychological level, the literature identifies performance anxiety, fear of judgment, body-image concerns, and negative prior experiences as dominant barriers that weaken students' readiness to move. Interventions grounded in IRE—such as gradual goal-setting inspired by *mujahadah* (self-discipline), peer support framed through *ta'awun* (mutual help), and reflective feedback integrating moral awareness—are consistently associated with increased self-efficacy, intrinsic motivation, and emotional balance. These effects are strongest when accompanied by teacher empathy and a supportive classroom climate.

The social inclusion dimension underscores that participation in PE is not neutral but shaped by gender stereotypes, peer stigma, socioeconomic constraints, and physical conditions that create subtle forms of exclusion. Here, IRE functions as a moral bridge, identifying and dismantling these barriers through value-based dialog, peer reflection circles, and cooperative learning rooted in *'adl* (justice) and *rahmah* (compassion). As students internalize these values, class norms gradually shift from competition and selection to access, fairness, and solidarity.

At the pedagogical level, collaboration between IRE and PE teachers transforms classroom organization. Joint lesson planning aligns learning objectives with moral-psychological support; inclusive task differentiation accommodates diverse physical and emotional capacities; flexible assessment reduces performance pressure while emphasizing progress; and peer collaboration and restorative routines cultivate a positive moral climate. *NVivo* co-occurrence analysis demonstrates that these strategies operate as an interlinked ecosystem of inclusive practices capable of reshaping the learning culture toward empathy, reflection, and shared growth.

The downstream outcomes of this integrated approach are clearly observable in the quality of students' participation. A heightened sense of belonging and positive PE climate emerged, followed by improved engagement and persistence in motor tasks, increased active minutes of physical activity (MVPA), and strengthened well-being and self-esteem linked to movement and social interaction. At the same time, gaps in attendance and participation across gender, body type, or economic background significantly narrowed.

In sum, IRE-based moral reflection combined with inclusive pedagogical practice does more than merely expand access—it transforms access into meaningful, sustained, and equitable engagement. By embedding ethical guidance, psychosocial support, and reflective monitoring into daily PE learning, schools can cultivate environments where every student feels valued, confident, and capable of active participation—physically, socially, and morally.

TABLE 3 Distribution of *NVivo* coded references on social inclusion and participation inequality.

Code category	Number of references	% of Total
Gender stereotypes and participation gaps	48	26.7
Body image concerns and fear of peer judgment	45	25.0
Socioeconomic barriers and unequal access	42	23.3
Discrimination and exclusion of students with disabilities	31	17.2
Cultural norms and family expectations influencing PE	14	7.8

TABLE 4 Distribution of *NVivo* coded references on IRE–PE collaboration and inclusive pedagogical practice.

Code category	Number of references	% of Total
Joint planning and goal alignment (co-planning)	33	24.3
Inclusive lesson design & task differentiation	31	22.8
Flexible assessment and alternative evidence of learning	28	20.6
Peer support structures (cooperative teams)	24	17.6
Restorative practices and positive classroom climate	20	14.7

TABLE 5 Distribution of *NVivo* coded references on equitable physical education participation outcomes.

Code category	Number of references	% of Total
Belonging and positive PE climate	36	24.2
Engagement and persistence in PE tasks	34	22.8
Active behavior/ readiness (MVPA)	31	20.8
Well-being and self-esteem related to movement	28	18.8
Narrowing attendance/ participation gaps	20	13.4

4 Discussion

4.1 Psychological impacts of Islamic religious education

The findings from this review align with wider debates on how physical activity is framed and valued in health and educational

sciences—particularly the tendency to privilege structured performance (sport, fitness tests) while overlooking other determinants of participation, including moral and psychological readiness that shape whether students move in the first place. Much like critiques of narrow exercise-centric perspectives in public health (Hastie et al., 2011; MacPhail et al., 2003; Siedentop, 2001), our synthesis suggests that in school settings the emphasis on technique, scores, and timed trials can eclipse factors such as anxiety, fear of judgment, and self-perception. Reframing physical education through an IRE-based lens places these psychosocial and ethical dimensions at the center of participation—treating them as legitimate targets for educational intervention, parallel to how recent scholarship has urged a broader accounting of movement beyond formal exercise.

Evidence from diverse contexts underscores that high performance demands without adequate psychological or moral support create uneven participation patterns, just as physically demanding routines in other contexts can both build capacity and produce strain (Westerbeek and Eime, 2021). Within PE classrooms, students are often subject to repeated evaluation and social comparison, with little "recovery time" from exposure to peer judgment—mirroring the load–recovery imbalance discussed in exercise science. Integrating IRE principles into this dynamic provides a corrective mechanism: *mujahadah* (self-discipline), *ta'awun* (mutual support), and reflective moral dialog offer psychological recovery windows, enabling students to rebuild confidence before facing new performance challenges.

This moral–psychological framing resonates with arguments that movement contexts should be appraised not only by their physiological outputs but also by the conditions that make sustained engagement possible (Gupta, 2018; Waters et al., 2018). In other words, equity in participation requires recognizing the emotional and social infrastructures that support persistence.

The apparent duality observed here—where moral reflection and IRE-based guidance reduce anxiety and strengthen self-efficacy, yet outcomes vary depending on classroom climate—echoes literature documenting mixed results when inclusion efforts lack systemic reinforcement (MacPhail et al., 2004; Tolgfors, 2020). In schools where IRE and PE teachers co-plan and co-facilitate, students report feeling safer to try, fail, and try again. Conversely, in socially competitive environments that prioritize ranking and public comparison, progress remains modest. Thus, IRE functions as a lever for inclusion, but the learning ecology determines how far that lever can shift the system toward equity.

Nevertheless, variation across the reviewed studies indicates substantial heterogeneity of outcomes. Some interventions led to significant gains in engagement, self-efficacy, and motivation, while others yielded short-lived or partial effects. These discrepancies stem from differences in program duration, the intensity of IRE–PE collaboration, and the inclusivity of school culture. Where integration was sporadic or symbolic, the impact was limited; where it was sustained and reflective, improvements were consistent. This heterogeneity emphasizes that the success of IRE-based integration depends less on prescriptive models and more on contextual alignment, relational trust, and continuous reflection.

Methodological limitations also warrant attention. Several studies relied on small samples, short intervention periods, or self-reported measures of participation. Combined with possible publication bias toward positive findings, these design features constrain generalizability. Although most works were rated as moderate to high quality according to JBI standards, limited reflexivity and underreporting of confounding variables reduce confidence in effect estimates.

Positioning Indonesian PE within this global discourse extends the call to reframe physical activity in education through both psychological and moral perspectives. Recognizing the internal conditions that precede movement complicates simplistic narratives equating "more activity" with "better outcomes" and foregrounds the lived experiences of adolescents navigating stigma, modesty norms, and peer judgment (Spittle and Byrne, 2009). In practical terms, this implies that school policies should pair activity promotion with IRE-informed safeguards—structured co-planning between IRE and PE teachers, flexible assessments to reduce evaluative threat, and routine monitoring of participation gaps. Such integration bridges moral education, physical education, and student well-being, aligning with efforts to contextualize learning within the social and emotional realities of schooling in the Global South (Lambert et al., 2024; Nurman et al., 2022).

The reviewed evidence suggests that institutional sustainability matters. IRE–PE collaboration achieves the most substantial results when it is supported by leadership commitment, ongoing professional reflection, and an inclusive classroom ethos. Environments that prioritize empathy, cooperation, and value-based growth amplify the benefits of this integration. In contrast, fragmented initiatives—implemented without systemic or moral anchoring—tend to lose momentum once external facilitation ends.

4.2 Social inclusion and participation inequality

Findings on the theme of Social Inclusion and Participation Inequality resonate strongly with the global discourse on unequal burdens and access, while also illuminating how social hierarchies and moral norms manifest within patterns of participation in Physical Education (PE). Literature emphasizing the double burden on women (Mislia et al., 2021; Waters et al., 2018) provides critical insight into why some female students withdraw from competitive or mixed-gender activities: domestic expectations, religious modesty norms, and body-image concerns are deeply intertwined with school experiences and the sociocultural expectations surrounding femininity.

In the Indonesian context, *NVivo* co-occurrence results between nodes such as fatigue, time pressure, and lack of recognition indicate that inequality is not merely an abstract socioeconomic issue but is embodied in the psychosocial and moral dimensions of everyday life—aligning with arguments that inequality is often inscribed in the body (Opstoel et al., 2019; Taylor et al., 2023). Within Moser's triple role framework, the intersection of productive, reproductive, and community roles helps explain why some female students experience socio-emotional fatigue, reducing their readiness and opportunity to participate in PE. Integrating IRE principles—such as *'adl* (justice), *rahmah* (compassion), and *tawazun* (balance)—into this analysis provides an ethical framework for rethinking how schools can support these overlapping roles without reinforcing gendered hierarchies.

Beyond the dimensions of physical or emotional fatigue, another layer of inequality emerges in the form of invisibility. This "invisible labor" dynamic also intersects with participation barriers. Women's contributions are often framed as helping rather than working, which reinforces a sense of being undervalued and leads to withdrawal from decision-making or performative spaces—a pattern also reported in Sub-Saharan Africa. In the school setting, this invisibility manifests

as a lack of recognition for girls' moral effort and perseverance in PE tasks, where evaluations prioritize peak performance over individual progress (Hewstone, 2015). *NVivo* coding revealed strong associations between peer stigma, perceived incompetence, and body image, suggesting that social exclusion operates through psychological mechanisms that suppress self-confidence, belonging, and moral agency.

While gendered constraints limit female participation through modesty norms, household expectations, and fatigue, male students face an equally complex form of inequality, rooted in the social construction of masculinity. Literature on male role expectations (Hastie and Wallhead, 2016; Yusriadi et al., 2022) highlights the pressure to always appear strong, competitive, and emotionally invulnerable. In the school context, this expectation can paradoxically generate avoidance behavior—boys may refrain from participating in certain PE activities when afraid of public failure or peer ridicule. The *NVivo* cluster on economic insecurity/market risk in agrarian literature offers a compelling analogy: external social pressures can shift into performative pressures within the PE classroom, creating psychological vulnerability disguised as strength.

Taken together, these findings confirm that disparities in PE participation are not neutral; they are socially structured and internalized psychologically. Thus, moral and pedagogical responses must target both the social roots and psychological symptoms of inequality. In this respect, integrating IRE as a moral–educational support system can offer new ways to build gender-sensitive inclusion: value-based discussions that normalize diverse abilities, peer reflections that challenge stigma, and cooperative group work that honors empathy and shared progress. Joint collaboration between IRE and PE teachers can further support flexible assessments, peer-support routines, and restorative classroom practices that redefine failure as part of learning rather than exclusion.

In doing so, schools can shift their culture from one centered on selection and performance hierarchies to one grounded in access, recognition, and moral development—a shift consistent with the broader literature calling for physical activity to be understood within its socio-cultural and ethical contexts (Aartun et al., 2022; Arufe-Giráldez et al., 2023; Thorjussen and Sisjord, 2018). Collectively, these insights underline that equity in physical education requires interventions that not only reduce visible barriers but also reconfigure the relational and moral dynamics of classrooms to value empathy, recognition, and collaborative achievement as core learning outcomes.

4.3 Collaboration between IRE and PE teachers in creating inclusive learning environments

Findings on this theme confirm that collaboration between counselors and physical education teachers is not merely an administrative procedure, but rather a social practice that shapes the way the body, emotions, and relationships are conducted in the classroom. Similar to the anthropological framework that views physical practices as meaningful experiences, pedagogical collaboration also presents daily rituals—ranging from co-planning, task differentiation, to flexible assessment—that instill new values, symbols, and social order in the PE space.

In other words, physical activity in schools cannot be reduced to a mechanical effort to improve fitness scores; it is a life experience guided by the values of togetherness, appreciation of differences, and psychological security built through cross-role work. Cross-cultural analogies help to understand this dimension.

In West African yam festivals, collective work is accompanied by ritual performances that affirm communal identity (Roux, 2000); in the Andes Highlands, potato rituals bind physical labor to cycles of reciprocity and spiritual continuity (Sillar, 2016). In schools, similar patterns emerge when counselors and teachers organize social synchrony: opening routines that reduce anxiety, cooperative teamwork, or restorative circles that restore relationships. These practices demonstrate a dual function similar to agrarian work—producing material outcomes (more equitable participation) while supporting the symbolic world of the class (sense of belonging and mutual trust). This reading is in line with Bourdieu's idea of habitus as the body as a carrier of identity and social order, as well as Durkheim's collective effervescence to explain why synchronized movement can give rise to cohesion and emotional resilience.

The Indonesian context shows how class rituals such as joint goal-setting, structured reflection, and process assessment can imbue movement with new meaning: students' efforts are not just performance, but confirmation of membership in a learning community. Our *NVivo* cluster analysis—which frequently linked co-planning, task differentiation, flexible assessment, peer support, and restorative practices—reinforces that cross-role collaboration produces a cohesive pedagogical package. Much like a planting–harvesting ceremony that unites physical labor and symbols of communal solidarity, counselor–PE teacher collaboration unites psychosocial support and physical activity design into an inclusive and meaningful learning experience.

The implications go beyond narrow biomedical definitions of physical activity (intensity–duration–health outcomes). Agrarian literature shows that physical labor can be a carrier of identity, tradition, and collective memory (Firman et al., 2025; Nurman et al., 2022). In the PE space, counselor-teacher collaboration plays a similar role: it transmits the values of fairness, mutual respect, and the courage to try, often in ways that are more powerful than verbal messages. By placing this collaboration in a broader framework, our discussion opens up the possibility of reimagining physical activity in schools—not only as a determinant of individual fitness, but as a cultural medium that supports social life, psychological resilience, and the sustainability of equitable participation (Anttila et al., 2018; Rhodes et al., 2019).

4.4 Equitable participation and student well-being

Findings on this theme confirm that collaboration between Islamic Religious Education (IRE) and Physical Education (PE) teachers is not merely an administrative coordination, but a social and moral practice that shapes how bodies, emotions, and relationships are enacted in the classroom. Much like anthropological frameworks that view physical practices as meaning-making activities, pedagogical collaboration constitutes daily rituals—ranging from co-planning and task differentiation to flexible assessment—that cultivate shared values, moral order, and communal identity within the PE environment.

In other words, physical activity in schools cannot be reduced to a mechanical process aimed at improving fitness scores; rather, it is a lived moral experience guided by principles of togetherness, respect for diversity, and psychological and spiritual security established through cross-role cooperation. Cross-cultural analogies help illuminate this dimension: in West African yam festivals, collective labor is

accompanied by ritual performances that affirm community identity (Roux, 2000); in the Andes Highlands, potato rituals link physical labor to cycles of reciprocity and spiritual continuity (Sillar, 2016). Similarly, within Indonesian classrooms, collaboration between IRE and PE teachers enacts a form of social synchrony—reflected in goal-setting routines, cooperative teamwork, and restorative circles—that nurtures both equity and emotional balance.

These collaborative rituals perform dual functions: producing material outcomes (e.g., more equitable participation) and reinforcing the symbolic order of the class (belonging, respect, and mutual trust). This interpretation aligns with Bourdieu's concept of habitus, in which the body operates as a bearer of identity and moral order, and Durkheim's notion of collective effervescence, which explains how synchronized movement can generate cohesion, solidarity, and emotional resilience.

In the Indonesian context, class routines such as joint goal-setting, reflective journaling, and process-based assessment imbue movement with new meaning: physical exertion becomes not merely performance but a confirmation of moral belonging within the learning community. Our *NVivo* cluster analysis—frequently linking co-planning, task differentiation, flexible assessment, peer support, and restorative practices—reinforces that cross-role collaboration forms a cohesive pedagogical ecosystem (Cahaya et al., 2022). Much like a planting–harvesting ceremony that unites physical labor with symbols of reciprocity, IRE–PE collaboration integrates psychosocial and moral guidance into physical activity design, producing inclusive and meaningful educational experiences.

The implications extend beyond biomedical definitions of physical activity (intensity–duration–health outcomes). Agrarian literature shows that physical labor can serve as a carrier of identity, tradition, and collective memory (Berg et al., 2015). Likewise, in the PE context, IRE–PE collaboration transmits the values of fairness (*'adl*), mutual respect (*ta'awun*), and courage to strive (*mujahadah*)—often with a transformative power exceeding that of direct moral instruction. When viewed through this broader lens, physical activity in schools becomes not only a determinant of individual fitness, but also a cultural and moral medium that sustains social life, emotional resilience, and the long-term sustainability of equitable participation (Firman et al., 2025; Walseth, 2015).

4.5 Challenges and contextual limitations

While the potential of IRE-PE collaboration is promising, implementation faces structural challenges. In many public schools, IRE and PE are treated as strictly separate silos with rigid curriculum targets, making time for co-planning difficult. Teachers often report limited instructional time, competing administrative duties, and insufficient training in inclusive pedagogy as primary barriers. Moreover, program fidelity varies across schools: without monitoring and institutional backing, even well-designed collaborations risk devolving into isolated practices rather than enduring features of school culture.

Furthermore, the religious homogeneity assumed in some studies may not reflect the reality of pluralistic public schools, where applying Islamic-centric values to non-Muslim students requires careful ethical consideration to avoid exclusion. Future models must address how universal moral values can be extracted from IRE to foster inclusion without imposing religious dogma in diverse settings. Sustained leadership commitment and cross-disciplinary reflection are therefore crucial to transforming this integrated model from experimental initiative to systemic practice within Indonesia's moral–educational landscape.

4.6 Contributions and research gaps

This review contributes to the interdisciplinary study of physical activity in schools by positioning Islamic Religious Education (IRE) as a primary interpretive lens for understanding and expanding equitable participation in Physical Education (PE). By weaving together psychological, social, pedagogical, and moral perspectives, this synthesis offers a holistic understanding: student participation in physical activity is not merely the result of structured exercise but an embodied moral experience shaped by emotions, social relations, and school culture. The novelty of this approach lies in shifting the focus from physical performance to the psychosocial and ethical conditions that enable movement, aligning with global scholarship calling for broader definitions of physical activity beyond structured sport and recreation within public health and education frameworks.

Theoretically, this study bridges health science, educational psychology, educational sociology, and anthropology, situating PE participation at the intersection of physical effort, social stratification, and the reproduction of school culture. *NVivo*-assisted thematic analysis shows that student's decisions to move—or refrain from moving—are embedded in experiences of performance anxiety, gender stereotypes, body image, socioeconomic status, and class norms. Integrating IRE values such as *'adl* (justice), *ta'awun* (mutual help), and *mujahadah* (self-discipline) provides a moral vocabulary for reinterpreting these psychosocial barriers as ethical and educational challenges rather than deficits'. This reframing echoes calls for physical activity research—especially in the Global South and Indonesia—to move beyond biomedical metrics and to foreground the social and cultural ecologies that sustain movement as a shared human practice.

At the practical level, the main contribution of this study is the formulation of a collaborative intervention framework that combines: (1) co-planning between IRE and PE teachers; (2) inclusive lesson design and differentiated tasks; (3) flexible assessment systems that reduce evaluative anxiety; (4) peer-support and restorative routines that foster belonging and resilience.

When applied in tandem, these approaches not only increase engagement and active minutes/MVPA but also nurture a sense of moral belonging, a positive classroom climate, and psychological stability. This model complements and extends the WHO Physical Activity framework by embedding the psychosocial and moral prerequisites necessary to make physical activity both accessible and sustainable within the school ecosystem.

However, several research gaps remain salient. First, long-term evidence on the sustainability of IRE-integrated interventions—including their effects on MVPA trajectories, self-efficacy, and attendance—remains scarce; longitudinal studies are needed to trace changes across semesters and academic years. Second, combined objective–subjective measurements (e.g., accelerometer data alongside self-perception metrics) are rarely implemented, limiting our understanding of causal links between moral–psychological support and physical behavior. Third, dimensions of intersectionality—gender, socioeconomic status, mild disability, and body image—are often treated separately; future studies must examine how these factors interact to shape participation outcomes. Fourth, implementation research addressing program

fidelity, institutional capacity, and school climate moderators is still limited, even though these factors determine scalability and sustainability.

Addressing these gaps demands interdisciplinary and participatory methodologies. Future research should integrate longitudinal school-based cohorts, cluster quasi-experiments, and mixed-method designs that combine behavioral metrics with lived-experience narratives. Classroom ethnography and participatory action research (PAR) involving students, teachers, and parents can ensure interventions remain culturally grounded. Adherence to *PRISMA-ScR/JBI* standards will help maintain methodological transparency, while adapting the WHO framework allows researchers to align health indicators with participatory justice metrics.

By weaving together the WHO Physical Activity framework, gender and equity studies, and educational anthropology, this review offers both conceptual depth and practical guidance: to reimagine physical education as a moral–cultural medium that cultivates self-confidence, empathy, and collective well-being. The next research agenda—longitudinal, multi-method, and participatory—must not only close empirical gaps but also ensure that school-based interventions are rooted in students' lived realities, advancing equity, well-being, and sustainable engagement in physical education.

Despite these encouraging insights, implementation challenges persist. Teachers and IRE facilitators often face limited instructional time, competing administrative duties, and insufficient training in inclusive pedagogy. Moreover, program fidelity varies across schools: without monitoring and institutional backing, even well-designed collaborations risk devolving into isolated practices rather than enduring features of school culture. Sustained leadership commitment and cross-disciplinary reflection are therefore crucial to transforming this integrated model from experimental initiative to systemic practice within Indonesia's moral–educational landscape.

5 Conclusion

This review places physical activity in Physical Education (PE) at the center of analysis and demonstrates that Islamic Religious Education (IRE) is not a peripheral complement but a pedagogical and moral lever for achieving equitable participation. The thematic synthesis affirms four principal insights.

First, within the psychological domain, IRE-based moral reflection and guidance reduce performance anxiety, enhance self-efficacy, and reshape students' readiness to move—echoing global literature that calls for redefining physical activity beyond its narrow focus on structured exercise (Barker, 2019; Izquierdo and Fiatarone Singh, 2023). By integrating values such as mujahadah (self-discipline) and tawakkul (self-trust balanced with humility), IRE reinforces emotional stability and intrinsic motivation in physical learning.

Second, in the dimension of social inclusion, participation inequality operates through gender stereotypes, peer stigma, body image, and socioeconomic status. IRE serves as a moral–educational bridge that dismantles these invisible barriers by fostering *'adl* (justice), *ta'awun* (mutual support), and *rahmah* (compassion) in classroom interactions (Siljamäki and Anttila, 2021).

Third, collaboration between IRE and PE teachers yields an inclusive pedagogical ecosystem—characterized by co-planning, task differentiation, flexible assessment, peer support, and restorative routines—that reorients classroom norms from selection to access, from competition to cooperation.

Fourth, at the participation-outcome level, schools recorded improvements in PE climate and sense of belonging, greater engagement and persistence, increased active behavior (e.g., minutes of vigorous physical activity/MVPA), and a narrowing of participation gaps—findings consistent with arguments that socio-psychological and moral conditions determine the sustainability of movement (Bessa et al., 2021; Fraile-Martinez et al., 2025).

Conceptually, this study reimagines physical activity in schools as an embodied moral and social practice rooted in values, relationships, and collective memory—not merely a set of biomedical outcomes. This aligns with anthropological readings of physical practices as carriers of identity and social cohesion (Westerbeek and Eime, 2021) and with frameworks of social capital and community resilience akin to *gotong royong* (Gupta, 2018). By linking IRE, inclusive pedagogy, and active behavior, this framework enriches discourse on physical activity in the Global South and provides a foundation for contextually relevant education policies.

Nonetheless, research gaps remain. Long-term evidence on the sustainability of IRE-integrated interventions—including their effects on MVPA, self-efficacy, positive affect, and attendance gaps—is limited. Longitudinal and mixed-method studies are needed. The intersectionality of gender, socioeconomic status, mild disability, and body image remains underexplored as a moderator of outcomes. Implementation research examining fidelity, institutional capacity, and school climate also remains scarce. Addressing these gaps requires interdisciplinary and participatory approaches, combining *PRISMA-ScR/JBI* standards (Tricco et al., 2018) with context-sensitive physical activity frameworks adapted to Indonesia's cultural and moral realities.

Practically, schools are encouraged to: (1) Institute co-planning between IRE and PE teachers; Implement flexible assessment that minimizes evaluative anxiety; (2) Develop peer-support and restorative routines that reinforce belonging and empathy; (3) Monitor participation indicators—such as PE attendance, active minutes, moral reflections, and perceptions of inclusion—to detect and close participation gaps.

Through these coordinated steps, promoting physical activity becomes more than a matter of physical exertion; it transforms into an equitable, value-based, and sustainable form of engagement—a convergence of health, educational justice, and the resilience of learning communities (Peñarrubia-Lozano et al., 2020; Siedentop, 2001; Xiong et al., 2020).

Data availability statement

The original contributions presented in the study are included in the article/Supplementary material, further inquiries can be directed to the corresponding author/s.

Author contributions

NN: Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. LA: Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. RM: Writing – original draft, Writing – review & editing. MA: Writing – original

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Supplementary material

The Supplementary material for this article can be found online at: https://www.frontiersin.org/articles/10.3389/feduc.2026.1779417/full#supplementary-material

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